

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 31

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: A librarian, on the last evening before her small branch library closes for good, completes her final rounds and finds an unexpected reminder of the years she has spent there.

1

At seven minutes past eight on the final Friday, I stood in the doorway of the children's corner and watched the lamp do what it had done every evening for twenty-one years. It threw its small, biscuit-coloured circle onto the carpet, lit the bean-bag that the under-fives had worn to the colour of weak tea, and made the cardboard rocket on the table look momentarily as though it might still take off. I had switched that lamp on for the first time on a Tuesday in February, when I was twenty-six and certain of very little except that this room mattered. I switched it off now, slowly, and the small circle vanished without ceremony.

2

The notice on the door, taped up six weeks ago, was already curling at one corner. "Branch closure: 31 March." Underneath, in a smaller font, "We thank you for twenty-one years of borrowing." I had not written that line; head office had. The polite, blameless syntax of it still made me wince. I had read it perhaps four hundred times — once for every person who had stopped, frowned, photographed it, and gone away looking embarrassed, as though they had been caught in some failure that was not, in fact, theirs.

3

There was nothing dramatic left to do. The shelves had been emptied earlier in the week, the better books boxed for the central branch and the rest given away in armfuls to schools, hospices and one slightly bewildered scout troop. What remained that evening were the bones of the place: empty bays, a creaking radiator, the smell of old paper that twenty-one years of varnish had been unable to disguise. I moved through them as one moves through a familiar house after the removal van has gone, touching things lightly, as if to confirm that they had been real.

4

On the returns trolley, which I had thought I had cleared, sat a single book. A library copy of a Roald Dahl, **The BFG**, well loved, its spine creased into a soft ridge. Mrs Aziz from Flat 14, I knew without checking the slip, had borrowed it for her grandson. I considered, for one foolish second, leaving it on the trolley. Then I picked it up and walked it to its place on the children's shelf, even though the children's shelf no longer existed, and the gesture had no audience but me. I slotted the book where it ought to have been, between **Matilda** and a thin volume on woodland birds, and I stepped back. Professional dignity, I thought, is mostly performed for one's own benefit.

5

The book did not stay closed. As I turned away, it slumped open at the middle, and a folded sheet of paper slid halfway out, the sort of paper a child uses when adults are not looking — faint-ruled, slightly torn. I picked it up. It was a letter, addressed in pencil and in careful capital letters to "THE LIBRARYAN". The spelling brought a small ache to my throat, of a kind I had not been expecting.

6

"Dear Libraryan," it read, "thank you for the book. It is my best book. My nan says you are closing. I am sorry you are closing. From Yusuf. Aged 7." Underneath, in even more careful capitals: "P.S. I will read it again before I give it back." There was no date. The book had been due back nine days ago, but I knew now that Yusuf — wherever he was tonight, with his nan and his other books and his Friday tea — had meant every word of the post-script. I stood there holding the letter, in a building that had ceased to be a library at the moment I had taken his book from the trolley, and I did not, for a moment, know quite where to put either of them.

7

I sat down on the low children's chair, which was always a mistake at my age, and read the letter twice more. Then I folded it again, along its original creases, and slipped it into the front pocket of my cardigan. I would, I decided, write Yusuf back. Not on library paper, which no longer existed, but on something of my own — perhaps a postcard from the museum I had always meant to visit on my newfound Saturdays. I would thank him for his letter. I would tell him the book was safe. I would not, on any account, tell him that I had cried.

8

I locked up at twenty-three minutes past eight, three minutes later than usual, because I checked the children's lamp twice. The street outside was empty. A bus hissed somewhere on the main road. I put the keys through the head office letterbox as instructed and walked, without looking back, towards the bus stop. In my pocket, against my ribs, Yusuf's letter weighed almost nothing at all.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator says the bean-bag had been "worn to the colour of weak tea." Explain, in your own words, what this detail suggests about the children's corner. [2]

2. What does the phrase "vanished without ceremony" suggest about the way the library is being closed? [2]

From Paragraph 2

3. The narrator says that the official notice has "polite, blameless syntax" that "made me wince." Explain, in your own words, why this wording troubles the narrator. [2]

From Paragraph 3

4. The narrator describes what remains in the library as “the bones of the place.” Explain what is **effective** about this image. [2]

From Paragraph 4

5. The narrator shelves a returned book even though “the children’s shelf no longer existed, and the gesture had no audience but me.”

(a) What does this action reveal about her character? [1]

(b) She concludes that “professional dignity... is mostly performed for one’s own benefit.” Explain, in your own words, what she means. [1]

From Paragraph 5

6. The narrator notices that the misspelling “THE LIBRARYAN” brings “a small ache to my throat, of a kind I had not been expecting.” Explain how the language used here suggests her emotional state. Support your answer with **two** details from Paragraph 5. [3]

From Paragraph 6

7. Yusuf writes, “P.S. I will read it again before I give it back.” What does this post-script suggest about Yusuf? [2]

8. The narrator says she stood “in a building that had ceased to be a library at the moment I had taken his book from the trolley.” What does this sentence suggest about her feelings towards the building? [1]

From Paragraph 7

9. Give **one** piece of evidence from Paragraph 7 that shows the narrator is trying to maintain her composure. [1]

From Paragraph 8

10. The narrator notes that Yusuf’s letter “weighed almost nothing at all” in her pocket. What does this final detail suggest about the **significance** the letter has for her? [2]

11. What is the **tone** of the final paragraph? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]

Text 4: A feature article examining why so many young adults today report feeling chronically lonely.

1

For most of the twentieth century, loneliness was understood as the quiet trouble of the elderly: a widower at his kitchen table, a great-aunt who counted Sundays by the church bells. It surprised researchers, then, when survey after survey began to report that the loneliest age group in many developed economies was no longer the over-seventies but the eighteen-to-twenty-fours. A 2023 study by the Office for National Statistics in the United Kingdom found that nearly one in four young adults said they felt lonely “often or always” — almost three times the rate of pensioners. Similar figures, with varying definitions, have since emerged from Australia, Singapore, the United States and Japan. The word “epidemic” — once a strong term — is now used by ministries of health with a straight face.

2

The most striking feature of this loneliness is its paradoxical setting. It is not a loneliness of empty rooms and silent telephones. The young adults in question are, by any historical measure, in constant contact: their phones buzz with group chats, their feeds refresh with the faces of acquaintances, their inboxes carry messages from people three time zones away. And yet the same people, asked privately, report that they do not have a single friend they could phone at two in the morning. The volume of contact has gone up; the depth, it appears, has fallen sharply through the floor.

3

Part of the explanation lies in the disappearance of what sociologists, after Ray Oldenburg, call “third places” — settings other than home (the first place) and work or school (the second) where one falls into casual, unplanned conversation with people one has not chosen. The neighbourhood library, the local café, the church hall, the pub, the community sports club: all of these have, in many cities, either closed, become too expensive, or been quietly displaced by businesses that prefer customers to keep moving. A young adult in 2025 may have many “communities” online and very few places, in physical space, in which to bump into a near-stranger.

4

Remote and hybrid work have, on balance, made this worse. The change has clear benefits, of course: a shorter commute, more flexibility, the ability to live further from a city centre. But it has also stripped away the slow, low-stakes companionship of an office — the lift conversation, the kettle queue, the after-work drink that nobody planned. For a graduate joining the workforce in 2025, the colleague one has never met in person is not a curiosity; it is the norm. Friendships built at work — historically a major source of mid-life companionship — are now harder to make and easier to drop.

5

The medical evidence is no longer in doubt. Chronic loneliness, sustained over months, is associated with elevated levels of the stress hormone cortisol, with shorter and more fragmented sleep, and — in study after study — with measurably worse cardiovascular outcomes. One widely cited meta-analysis put the long-term mortality risk of persistent loneliness on a par with smoking fifteen cigarettes a day. The body, it seems, was built for company; deprived of it for long enough, it begins, slowly and quietly, to break down. This is not a metaphor. It is a clinical fact.

6

What, then, are the responses? Employers, particularly the larger ones, have begun to mandate in-office days, to fund team retreats, and — in a few cases — to pay for therapy. Schools and universities are running structured “friendship interventions” that look uncomfortably like dating apps but are, by all accounts, well received by lonely students who would not otherwise admit they were lonely. Governments,

too, are paying attention: both the United Kingdom and Japan now have ministers with explicit responsibility for loneliness. Individuals, meanwhile, are rediscovering some startlingly old-fashioned remedies — running clubs, choirs, board-game nights, weekly walks with a neighbour — and reporting, perhaps to their own surprise, that these things actually work.

7

None of which is to claim that the problem is close to solved. Loneliness, like obesity or short-sightedness, is the product of a way of life, and ways of life shift slowly. But the assumption that young adulthood is, by its nature, the most socially abundant period of one's life is no longer safe to make. If the loneliness of the young is to be taken as seriously as the loneliness of the old — and the evidence increasingly suggests it should be — then the places, the working patterns and the habits that surround a person between the ages of eighteen and twenty-four will need to be examined as carefully as the medical conditions that surround a person between sixty-eight and seventy-four. The trouble is no longer a quiet one. It would be foolish to pretend it is.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer says that the word “epidemic” is “now used by ministries of health with a straight face.” Explain, in your own words, what this phrase suggests about the change in attitudes towards young-adult loneliness. [2]

From Paragraph 2

13. Why does the writer describe the loneliness of young adults as having a “paradoxical setting”? Answer in your own words. [2]

14. The writer says that “the depth, it appears, has fallen sharply through the floor.” What does the writer mean by this? [1]

From Paragraph 3

15. Explain, in your own words, what sociologists mean by a “third place.” [2]

16. According to Paragraph 3, give **two** reasons why such places have disappeared in many cities. [2]

From Paragraph 4

17. The writer describes “the lift conversation, the kettle queue, the after-work drink that nobody planned” as “slow, low-stakes companionship.” Explain what is **effective** about this description. [2]

From Paragraph 5

18. The writer ends Paragraph 5 with the short sentences, “This is not a metaphor. It is a clinical fact.” Why does he do this? [2]

From Paragraph 6

19. The writer describes the “friendship interventions” in schools and universities as looking “uncomfortably like dating apps.” What is the writer's **tone** in this phrase? [1]

20. Give **two** examples from Paragraph 6 of “startlingly old-fashioned remedies” that individuals have rediscovered. [2]

From Paragraph 7

21. The writer ends by saying, “The trouble is no longer a quiet one.” Explain what is **effective** about this final sentence. [2]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **the causes of chronic loneliness among young adults** and **the responses being attempted by employers, institutions and individuals**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 3 to 6** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Young adults today are lonely partly because ...

— END OF PAPER —